

REVIEWS

story remarkably similar to the Pazzi conspiracy in Florence in 1478), but the particular crisis affords the opportunity for an examination of the major political, social and economic trends in Flanders at that time. The work is so devised by Professor Ross that his introductory survey and the notes on Galbert's text are partly independent of one another in presentation, his purpose being to facilitate an informed reading of the text without the need for frequent cross-reference to the introduction (xii). But this is an unsatisfactory arrangement, resulting in much needless repetition both of argument and bibliographical data, a weakness unfortunately revealed also in numerous instances within the notes themselves. The introduction and critical apparatus are impressively erudite and informative, but meticulous to a fault: it is (for example) certainly unnecessary in a study of this kind to explain the meaning of such terms as 'octave' (151 n. 1) when they occur merely incidentally, to define the basic rules of the Roman dating system (118 n. 1), or to write a biographical note on St. Benedict when his feast day is mentioned in passing (186 n. 1); nor is there much profit in the insertion of simply speculative questions on minor points of incidental detail (178 n. 2, 181 n. 2, 217 n. 8, etc.). Several bibliographical and typographical slips have passed uncorrected (12 n. 34 and 336, 40 n. 169, 149, 219, 244 n. 9, 267, 320 n. 3, etc.), and there is a curious dating error in the text where 3 February is identified as the sixth day after the feast of the Purification (266). Despite these blemishes, Professor Ross has produced an interesting and scholarly book, though its value would be greatly increased by the drastic excision of unnecessary detail and the adoption of a more succinct and consistent system of references.

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Gioacchino da Fiore: la Piu' Singolare ed Affascinante Figura del Medioevo Cristiano.

By Antonio Crocco. (Collana 'I Grandi Ideali dello Spirito', i). Pp. 204 + 2 plates. Naples: Edizioni Empireo, 1960. Lire 3,200.

Almost every recent writer on Joachim of Fiore has commented on the vast bibliography and great variety of judgments clustering round his name. In the sixteenth century he appeared in catalogues of both saints and heretics and today the central argument still turns on whether he should be classed as orthodox or heterodox. Italian historians have been foremost in this controversy and, again as in the sixteenth century, some have been especially vehement in attack or defence. The chief merit of Professor Crocco's book lies in the fact that, although he clearly takes the side of defending the abbot's orthodoxy, he does so in a thoroughly judicious manner, weighing the evidence and the arguments with a care that inspires confidence. He has, it is true, little to add to our knowledge of Joachim's life, works and thought. Chapter i, on his life, is no more than a useful summary. Chapter ii, on Joachim's writings, adopts a canon of the authentic works which is generally sound, although an undifferentiated group of 'minor works' is consigned too hastily to a footnote (35). Professor Crocco then attempts a short summary of each of the main works: he should have known that Joachim's writings were not susceptible of logical summarising in this way. In particular, his division of the figures in the *Liber Figurarum* into four categories will not work since so many of them contain elements from more than one category. In chapters iii and iv Professor Crocco deals with Joachim's Trinitarian conception of history and the concept of the Age of the

Spirit. Although he describes the first as *il più grandioso disegno di teologia della storia* (77) and the second as *il più luminoso sogno del misticismo medievale* (83), both chapters are sketchy and do little to reveal the richness and intricacy of Joachim's thought and imagery in this central area of his doctrine. He does, however, underline one important point on which the reviewer is in agreement with him against some other historians: *L'epoca dello Spirito*, he says, *non rappresenterà quindi il tramonto della Chiesa visibile gerarchica e del Papato—come ritengono il Grundmann ed il Benz, che sembrano fare di Gioacchino quasi un precursore della Riforma, e come sostenne il Buonaiuti, dominato nelle sue indagini da mal celate preoccupazioni modernistiche—ma la loro massima glorificazione* (94-5). An error common to many expositors of Joachim's system is repeated in the assertion that Joachim stated that the Third Age would begin in the year 1260 (74). For a summary of the evidence on this point, reference may be made to an article on 'The Figuræ of Joachim of Fiore' in *Mediaeval and Renaissance Studies*, iii (1954), 190 n.1. Chapter v, on Joachim's Trinitarian theology, with its excursus on the Tetragrammaton, embodies Professor Crocco's major interest in Joachimist studies and is probably the most valuable part of the book. He insists that Joachim drew his main inspiration, not from the Greek Church, but from the great Latin Fathers, especially St. Augustine (111). Chapters vi, on Joachimism in the thirteenth century, and vii, on Dante and Joachim, are too slight to add significantly to our knowledge. Taken as a whole, the sympathy and imagination with which this book is written make it a pleasing introduction to the subject, whilst the sober judgment on controversial points ensures that it is a reliable one. It does not, however, contribute much that is new and it appears to bury Joachimism too soon. To place the '*ultima sera del Gioacchinismo*' in the time of Cola di Rienzo (163) is misleading, for the abbot's influence was by no means extinguished in the mid-fourteenth century and some of the most interesting problems of Joachimism concern its later manifestations in the fifteenth, sixteenth and even seventeenth centuries.

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L'Abbaye Saint-Martin de Tournai de 1290 à 1350: origines, évolution et dénouement d'une crise. By Albert d'Haenens. (Université de Louvain, Recueil de Travaux d'Histoire et de Philologie, IV^e Série, Fasc. 23). Pp. 322 + 4 plates + 3 maps. Louvain: Éditions Nauwelaerts, 1961. Belgian Frs. 320.

This is a study of the history of one of the great abbeys of western Europe during the sixty years in which it passed from affluence and high repute to a state of poverty, squalor and laxity, from which it was rescued to become once more economically sound and monastically respectable, if with reduced numbers and resources. The causes of the decline were in part spiritual and in part economic. Between 1281 and 1321 three abbots ruled the house ill. The first, a worldly man, neglected his abbey and lived luxuriously. To remedy the consequent financial stringency he instituted the *peculium* or wage-system, separated the households of abbot and community, and alienated lands at a premium for one or more lives. His successor continued to spend for personal satisfactions and transferred or allowed to depart a number of monks in order to lower expenses. When he was at last deposed the reduced community were at sixes and sevens, and elected their youngest member. Before he could show his mettle he died, leaving great debts and the prospect of another heavy payment to the